

a natural extension of the postmodern world, a digital archive for our descendents to unravel, a domain name that is used as a verb, and a blow in the face of any police state trying to keep the publication of content in control. But before it was all this, YouTube was a mere startup. This was in a simpler time when Netflix and chill was basically a dinner date at the movies, and the Internet was a compendium of simple text and images. There was to be a period of roughly 20 months that would thoroughly transform everything. Between Feb. 14, 2005 and Oct. 9, 2006, the world of video was to change completely.

The making of a new verb: 20 months of change

On Feb. 14, 2005, 3 former Paypal employees registered the domain name 'youtube.com', and officially created the company. They were Chad Hurley, Steve Chen, and Jawed Karim. With great creation comes great mythos, and the same is true with YouTube. It is claimed that after taking videos at a get-together that Hurley and Chen went to, they couldn't find an efficient way to share the video online, so they decided to do something about it. Although Jawed Karim decided to leave the company in its early days to pursue a PhD at Stanford, he said that two separate incidents crystallized the need for such a website – the famous Janet Jackson wardrobe malfunction, and the tsunami of 2004. What do these disparate events have in common? You couldn't find video of it online.

Initially, YouTube was called a dating site. Inspired by HotorNot, they decided to create something where the users populated the website with content of their own. They even ran Craigslist ads asking women to upload videos for \$20 a pop. They didn't get a single response. Because there wasn't really much content on it, Karim uploaded videos of aeroplanes taking off and landing, and a now-famous 18 second video called 'Me at the zoo', where he says that the interesting thing about elephants is that they have long trunks. Another pivot they took in 2007 was to make it a private video messaging service – where the user makes a video and shares it with some of their friends. To be perfectly honest, this wasn't that far off. To get the modern day YouTube, all you have to do is replace 'friends' with 'the world'.

In July 2005, Keith Rabios, a former PayPal executive who became a VC, impulsively invested in YouTube after watching the full half hour of content that the website hosted at that point of time. YouTube was based on Adobe Flash, and this was the clincher for Rabios. Its utility was such that a user